How to Evaluate the Source of Information

Evaluating a source relies heavily on lateral reading—leaving the article itself to see what other independent, authoritative sources say about the publisher.

The SIFT Method (Mike Caulfield)

The SIFT framework provides a quick four-step routine for digital literacy and fact-checking:

1. **Stop:** Before sharing or acting on an emotional headline, check your initial reaction. Ask if you know the reliability of the website or author.
2. **Investigate the Source:** Open a new tab and search for the author, domain, or organization. Look up their reputation on neutral reference sites or news aggregators.
3. **Find Better Coverage:** Look for trusted, established news or research organizations reporting on the same claim. If only one unknown site is making the claim, proceed with caution.
4. **Trace Claims to Original Context:** Follow quotes, stats, or scientific claims back to the primary paper, official dataset, or original video recording to ensure context hasn't been twisted.

Essential Source Verification Checklist

Verification Metric	Red Flags	Reliable Signs
Domain & URL	Misspelled domain names mimicking major outlets (e.g., additions).	Verified institutional domain (established publisher, .edu, .gov)
Author Attribution	Unlisted author, generic administrator, or pseudonymous profile.	Named author with verifiable expertise, institutional affiliation, or publication record.
Corroboration	No other outlet is reporting the story; cited links lead to dead pages or circular references.	Cited primary sources, hyperlinked research papers, or corroboration by independent fact-checkers.
Correction Policy	No clear owner, missing contact page, or absence of transparent correction logs.	Clear editorial standards, explicit corrections process, and transparent funding/ownership details.

Practical Verification Tools & Resources

- **Fact-Checking Portals:**

    - **FactCheck.org** (https://www.factcheck.org/): For political claims, policy analysis, and viral speeches.
    - **PolitiFact (https://politifact.com/):** For political claims, policy analysis, and viral speeches.
    - **Snopes (https://www.snopes.com/):** For urban legends, viral social media posts, and altered images.
    - **Full Fact (https://fullfact.org/):** For international news, statistical claims, and policy claims.
- **Technical Search Tools:**
    - **Reverse Image Search:** Use Google Images, TinEye, or Google Lens to locate where an image first appeared and see if it was cropped or repurposed.
    - **InVID Verification Plugin:** A browser extension designed for journalists to inspect video metadata, extract keyframes for image searches, and analyze deepfake indicators.
    - **Wayback Machine (http://wayback.archive.org/):** Useful for checking past versions of modified or deleted web pages.